baaskaraa

PRESS KIT

A traditional painter. A digital creator. A poet.
Now a multidisciplinary artist.

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PREVIEW EDITION · OCTOBER 2026



baaskaraa, 2026. Photograph: Deva Baskar

AT A GLANCE

baaskaraa

An Indian artist based in Singapore, working across painting, sculpture, digital art and Tamil poetry.

Artist name	baaskaraa (always lower case)
Born	Baskar, 1974, Irumbulikkurichi, Tamil Nadu, India
Lives and works	Singapore, since 2000; studios in Singapore and Irumbulikkurichi
Practice	Painting, sculpture, digital art, Tamil poetry
Training	Government College of Arts and Crafts, Chennai (founded 1850): Bachelor of Fine Arts, Painting, First Class with Distinction, 1999
Collection	National Gallery of Modern Art, New Delhi (acquired 1997)
Recognition	India: VTI Mahatma Gandhi Birth Centenary Memorial Award, 1998; Tamil Nadu State Award, 1998 · USA: PromaxBDA Global Excellence Award, Bronze, Los Angeles, 2015 · Singapore: Golden Point Award for Tamil Poetry, 2011 and 2013; Bird Sanctum, commissioned for Project LAVA by the National Arts Council and the National Library Board, 2014
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BIOGRAPHY

Short biography

baaskaraa (born Baskar, 1974, Tamil Nadu, India) is an Indian artist based in Singapore, working across painting, sculpture, digital art and Tamil poetry. Trained at the Government College of Arts and Crafts, Chennai, India's oldest art school, he had a work acquired by the National Gallery of Modern Art, New Delhi, while still a student. He has twice received Singapore's Golden Point Award for Tamil Poetry.

Biography

baaskaraa is an Indian artist based in Singapore, working across painting, sculpture, digital art and Tamil poetry.

Born Baskar in 1974 in Tamil Nadu, India, he trained at the Government College of Arts and Crafts, Chennai, India's oldest art school, graduating with First Class Distinction.

While still a student, his work entered the collection of the National Gallery of Modern Art, New Delhi.

In Singapore since 2000, he carried the painter's discipline into the screen, earning a PromaxBDA Global Excellence Award in Los Angeles for his design work at CNA, Mediacorp. He carried it into language too: he has twice been honoured with the Golden Point Award for Tamil Poetry.

Literature drives the work. Each piece begins as a thought, becomes a line, and only then takes form, often as a whole series.

Baskar. Becoming baaskaraa.

BIOGRAPHY · LONG

The full story

I · The village 1974–1994

He was born Baskar in 1974 in Irumbulikkurichi, a village in the Ariyalur district of Tamil Nadu, India.

The first images he knew were not in books. In the village stands the shrine of his family's deity, the kula deivam: an open-air sanctuary of giant painted horses and elephants, seated guardian warriors and small domed shrines beneath a great tree. Figures larger than a man, painted in full colour, standing in the open. These were the places that first inspired him.

At school he won first prizes three years running: for drawing in 1988 and 1989 at the Government High School, Irumbulikkurichi, and for painting in 1990 at the Government Higher Secondary School, Ponparappi. That same year he took second prize for an essay. The writer was already there.

In 1992 he passed the Government Technical Examination, Higher Grade, in freehand outline and model drawing. Two years later he left for Chennai and its art school.

The village never left the work. His home there is one of his three studios, and since 2014 Aalam has joined the village's people working in Singapore to the village at home.

II · Chennai 1994–2000

In 1994 he entered the Government College of Arts and Crafts, Chennai. Founded in 1850, it is India's oldest art school. The preparatory course took him through drawing, painting, printmaking, visual communication design, textile design, ceramics, photography and sculpture.

In his first year a watercolour of white daisies sold through the Victoria Technical Institute. It was his first sale, and it gave him the confidence to go on.

By 1997 he was exhibiting across India. With the Square Group, four young artists at Saga Art Gallery, Chennai, he drew reviews in The Hindu and Dinamani. His work was shown at the 40th National Exhibition of Art in Bangalore, and Abstract (gold and black) entered the collection of the National Gallery of Modern Art, New Delhi. A college study trip to Ooty set off the Ooty series: far landscapes, wholly imagined.

1998 brought three honours. The Victoria Technical Institute's Mahatma Gandhi Birth Centenary Memorial Award, for the oil painting My Native Land. The State Award of the Tamil Nadu Oviya Nunkalai Kuzhu, for Light on Scape Series-1, which The Hindu singled out for its handling of light. Second prize at Gandhi Mandapam, presented in the presence of the Governor and the Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu.

In 1999 he graduated Bachelor of Fine Arts in Painting, First Class with Distinction, with the Best Outgoing Student Award. The same year he earned a Diploma in Multimedia Design and Presentation, Grade A: the screen was already calling. He began the Master of Fine Arts, and in May 2000 held his first solo exhibition, A Portfolio of Art Happenings, at Apparao Galleries, Chennai. In October he left for Singapore.

BIOGRAPHY · LONG, CONTINUED

III · The painter who fell into language 2000–2013

In 2000 he landed in Singapore with a painter's hands and no canvas. What he found instead was a language: his own.

For nearly a decade he worked inside Tamil, building it in pixels and sound for the children of a new country. He drew it, animated it and edited its voice, frame by frame and syllable by syllable. Day after day the language passed through his hands, and something turned. His thoughts stopped arriving as images. They arrived as words.

So he wrote.

In 2003 he married Suguna, a poet. Two writers at one table, then twice a month at Kavimaalai and Kavi Solai, the Tamil poetry circles where Singapore's poets read and are judged by each other. It went on for over a decade. The circles became the national stage: the Golden Point Award for Tamil Poetry in 2011, and again in 2013, when Suguna took first prize in the same ceremony. Two poets, one home, one language.

In 2004 he became a life member of the Association of Singapore Tamil Writers, and served on its committee from 2006 to 2012. In 2011 he sat on the organising committee of the World Tamil Writers Conference, Singapore.

IV · From the word, the form 2007–2014

Then the words came back to the canvas. Today a work by baaskaraa begins as a thought, becomes a line, and only then becomes a form, often a whole series.

Bird Sanctum was the first time the public saw it: a Tamil novel turned into nests of real twigs, touring Singapore's national libraries in 2014. Commissioned for Project LAVA by the National Arts Council and the National Library Board, it grew from Ma. Elangkannan's novel Kuruvi Kottam. The twigs for the nest were gathered at MacRitchie Reservoir with the novelist himself. The work travelled to library@chinatown, Ang Mo Kio, Bedok and Jurong East, and on 18 July artist and novelist spoke together at Ang Mo Kio Library.

The same year he gave form to a poem by Suguna Baskar, Sinegam Theerndha Kaadhal: first as a digital sculpture, then as a painting.

The work also left the studio. In 2013, for Maya Dance Theatre's production GREY, he and the photographer Charlie Lim made the murals on the rooftop of the Singai Tamil Sangam in Little India, guiding the dancers, residents and students who painted them, with thanks to the National Arts Council. For four nights in June the walls were the stage. The murals have since been painted over; the photographs remain.

The theatre had called earlier. In 2007 his digital backdrops framed 37 Pearls at the Victoria Theatre, an evening of Tamil theatre and dance by the Singapore Indian Artistes' Association and the Manimaran Dance Group.

He doesn't illustrate literature. He writes it, and then he builds it.

BIOGRAPHY · LONG, CONTINUED

V · The same hand, on screen 2001–2023

Alongside the poet, a second discipline was growing: the screen. It began in 2001 with digital creation for Tamil language and culture, for Ministry of Education projects, and it became a profession.

From November 2008 he was Art and Visual Effects Director for television at Tantra Inc., Singapore: opening titles, trailers and visual effects for television series, art direction and effects for commercials, set design.

From 2010 to 2014 he worked independently, as a full-time painter, digital freelancer and founder of the RiGHTMiND studio.

In 2014 he joined Mediacorp as Senior Graphic Designer at CNA, Singapore's international news channel, and stayed nine years, designing motion graphics and branding for the channel. A CNA logo animation is his, from concept to final frame.

In 2015 that work was recognised in Los Angeles: a PromaxBDA Global Excellence Award, Bronze, in Art Direction & Design, Program-Specific Logo, for CNA's Documentary of the Week, presented at PromaxBDA's annual global conference alongside winners such as CNN and FX. In 2021 Mediacorp honoured him with its Long Service Award.

The screen never replaced the canvas. It trained the same hand in time, motion and light: the hand that now builds digital sculpture, 3D works and virtual space.

VI · Agam. Puram. Now. since 2010

In 2010 a second journey began, inward. Agam, the inner path, led him through the yogis and siddhas of Tamil tradition, to Arunachala and the temples of Tamil Nadu, back to the village gods, and to sit with masters in India and Singapore. Vasi Yoga in the Siddha tradition. Hatha Yoga from 2016. Nada from 2018.

Stillness opened into pure observation: a dialogue with no intention, in which questions arose and answered themselves. In his words: “Stillness opens into observation. A dialogue begins without intention. Questions arise and answer themselves. What remains is the artwork.” What remained, in May 2020, was Emergence: a living plant traced as line, the line set free, the line resolved into a gold sculpture in three dimensions.

Puram, the outer path, runs the other way. On 14 January 2014 he brought together the people of Irumbulikkurichi working in Singapore as Aalam, for the village at home: Pongal, village festivals, honouring the elders.

The line itself is the signature: non-stop, never defined, everything connected and flowing. The Unbroken Line, the line studies and a self-portrait, all of 2020, carry it.

Now the work turns on literature again. Vinayagar Agaval, after Avvaiyar's verse, has been in the making since a sketch of 3 February 2020. Kavi, a study of Suguna Baskar in gouache and Japanese gold, opens the way to a planned life-size portrait in oil and 24-carat gold.

Baskar. Becoming baaskaraa.

SELECTED CV

baaskaraa · born Baskar, 1974

EDUCATION

1994–1999	Bachelor of Fine Arts, Painting, First Class with Distinction, Government College of Arts and Crafts, Chennai (University of Madras)
1999	Diploma in Multimedia Design and Presentation, Grade A
1999–2000	Master of Fine Arts (first year), Government College of Arts and Crafts, Chennai

SOLO EXHIBITION

2000	*A Portfolio of Art Happenings*, c/o Apparao Galleries, Chennai, 15–30 May

SELECTED GROUP EXHIBITIONS

1995	16th All India Fine Arts Exhibition, Chitrakala Parishath, Bangalore
1997	40th National Exhibition of Art, Lalit Kala Akademi, Bangalore
1997	Square Group: *Paintings and Sculptures*, Saga Art Gallery, Chennai
1997	Kala Mela, New Delhi
1998	Tamil Nadu Oviya Nunkalai Kuzhu exhibition, Lalit Kala Akademi galleries, Chennai
1998	All India Drawing Exhibition, Jaipur

PUBLIC COLLECTION

1997	National Gallery of Modern Art, New Delhi: *Abstract (gold and black)*, 1996

LITERATURE

2004–	Life member, Association of Singapore Tamil Writers; committee 2006–2012
2011	Organising committee, World Tamil Writers Conference, Singapore

AWARDS

1998	Victoria Technical Institute, Mahatma Gandhi Birth Centenary Memorial Award, for *My Native Land*
1998	State Award, Tamil Nadu Oviya Nunkalai Kuzhu, for *Light on Scape Series-1*
1998	Painting competition, 2nd prize, Gandhi Mandapam, Chennai
1999	Best Outgoing Student Award, Government College of Arts and Crafts, Chennai
2011	Golden Point Award, Tamil Poetry, 3rd Prize, Singapore
2013	Golden Point Award, Tamil Poetry, 3rd Prize, Singapore
2015	PromaxBDA Global Excellence Award, Bronze, Los Angeles: Art Direction & Design, Program-Specific Logo, for CNA, Mediacorp
2021	Mediacorp Long Service Award

PUBLIC WORKS AND PROJECTS

2007	*37 Pearls*: digital stage backdrops, Victoria Theatre, Singapore
2013	*GREY*: rooftop murals for Maya Dance Theatre, Singai Tamil Sangam, Little India, with Charlie Lim, with thanks to the National Arts Council
2014	*Bird Sanctum*: installation for Project LAVA, National Arts Council and National Library Board; four public libraries

PROFESSIONAL

2001–2008	Tamil-language educational media with IT21 International, for Ministry of Education projects
2008–2010	Art and Visual Effects Director for television, Tantra Inc., Singapore
2010–2014	Independent painter and digital artist; founder, RiGHTMiND
2014–2023	Senior Graphic Designer, CNA, Mediacorp

RECOGNITION

Recognised in India, the USA and Singapore.



Receiving the painting prize, Gandhi Mandapam, Chennai, 2 October 1998



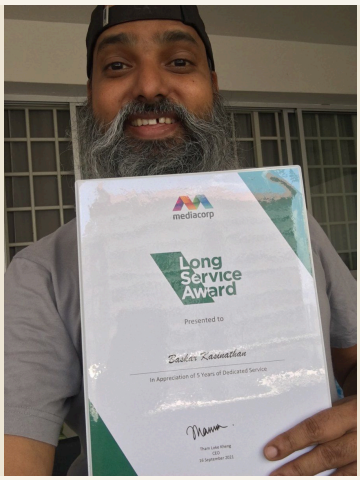
Victoria Technical Institute, Mahatma Gandhi Birth Centenary Memorial Award, presented 6 January 1999



Baskar and Suguna Baskar at the Golden Point Award, Singapore, 7 November 2013: her 1st Prize, his 3rd, for Tamil poetry



PromaxBDA Global Excellence Award, Bronze, Los Angeles, 2015



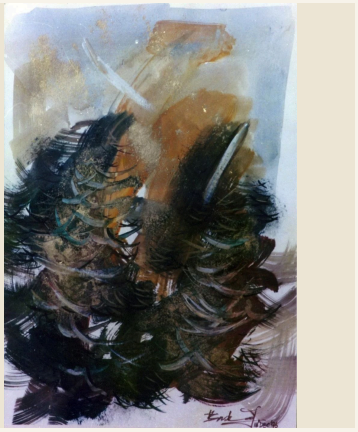
Mediacorp Long Service Award, 16 September 2021



Tamil Murasu, November 2013, on the Golden Point Award

SELECTED WORKS · 1996–1998

From the Chennai years



Abstract (gold and black), 1996
Mixed media · National Gallery of Modern Art, New Delhi
BK-1996-002



Banyan, Theosophical Society, Adyar, 1996
Acrylic on canvas
BK-1996-001



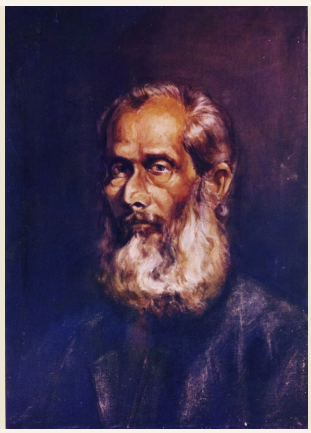
Hill path, 1997
Acrylic on canvas · Collection of Rubesh Kannan
BK-1997-045



My Native Land, 1998
Oil on canvas · VTI award, 1998
BK-1998-016



Light on Scape Series-1, 1998
Acrylic on paper, 90 × 120 cm · Tamil Nadu State Award, 1998
BK-1998-043



Portrait of an elder (bearded), 1998
Oil on canvas
BK-1998-017

SELECTED WORKS · 2014–2025

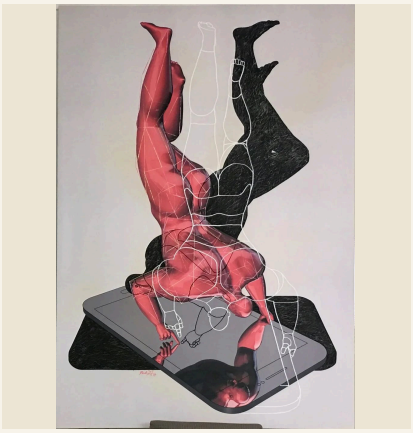
The line, in every medium



Look Within, 2014
Acrylic on canvas, 183 × 122 cm
BK-2014-051



Convergence, 2014
Mixed media on silver ground
BK-2014-047



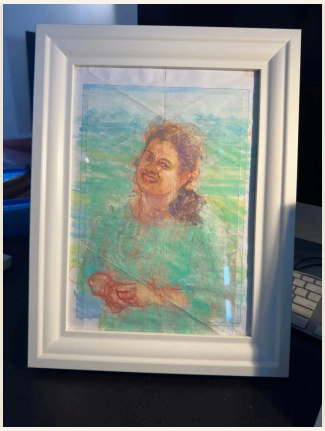
சினேகம் தீர்ந்த காதல் · Sinegam Theerndha Kaadhal, 2014
Digital sculpture printed on canvas, with oil · after the poem by Suguna Baskar
BK-2014-049



The Unbroken Line, 2020
Pastel on paper
BK-2020-054



Coral Figures, 2024
3D digital composition
BK-2024-061



Kavi: study for a portrait of Suguna Baskar, 2025
HIMI artist gouache (made in Japan) and Japanese gold paint on isometric grid paper, 29.7 × 21 cm
BK-2025-064

PROJECTS

The work beyond the studio



2014 · NATIONAL ARTS COUNCIL AND NATIONAL LIBRARY BOARD

Bird Sanctum · Project LAVA

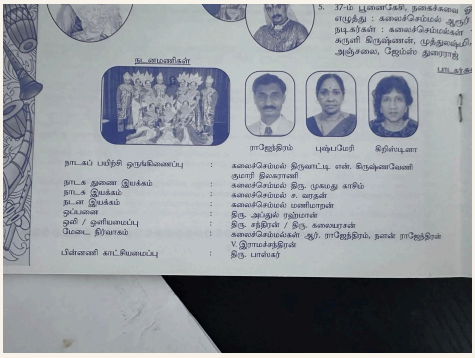
Bird Sanctum was one of four artworks chosen for the second Project LAVA in the Libraries, the NAC and NLB programme that pairs Singapore writing with visual art. It turned Ma. Elangkannan's Tamil novel Kuruvi Kottam into an installation of white birds around a nest that stands for home, on a pedestal in the shape of Singapore, and it travelled to four public libraries from May to August 2014.



2013 · SINGAI TAMIL SANGAM ROOFTOP, LITTLE INDIA

GREY · Maya Dance Theatre

GREY was a Maya Dance Theatre production staged on the rooftop of Singai Tamil Sangam, 02 Kampong Kapor Road, Little India, from 19 to 22 June 2013 at 8 pm. The programme credits the visuals and murals to Charlie Lim and Ka. Baskar: the rooftop walls, stairhouse and parapets were painted as a mural that became the environment for the dance, with members of the Kampong Glam Rowell Court Residents' Committee and students from the Republic Polytechnic Indian Cultural Group painting alongside. Baskar also made a promotional video in support of the event. With thanks to the National Arts Council.



2007 · SIAA AND MANIMARAN DANCE GROUP

37 Pearls · Victoria Theatre

முத்துக்கள் 37 PEARLS was an evening of Tamil theatre and dance at Victoria Theatre on Saturday 3 March 2007, presented jointly by the Singapore Indian Artistes' Association and the Manimaran Dance Group, with Dr SP Thinnappan as Guest of Honour. Baskar created the background scenery: digital stage backdrops for the programme, which included the historical play Raja Raja Chozhan, dances by the Manimaran group and the comedy 37-ம் புலிகேசி.

PRESS

What the critics wrote

“The abstract work ‘Light on Scape Series — I’ by K. Baskar is quite effective in the way he handles the light.”

The Hindu, 11 September 1998, “Questions on identity”, Lakshmi Venkatraman

“K. Baskar’s paintings in acrylic and watercolour are a feast for the eyes! … In the way he uses colour there is a gentleness, a coolness.”

Dinamani–Vellimani, 17 October 1997, S. Guru (translated from Tamil)

“Due to his interest in transparency he prefers watercolours and acrylics. Both of them are quite attractive and reveal his skill in his chosen medium.”

The Hindu, 26 September 1997, “Display of artistic skills”, Lakshmi Venkatraman

PRESS LIST

1997	The Hindu, 26 September: “Display of artistic skills”, Lakshmi Venkatraman (Square Group)
1997	Dinamani–Vellimani, 17 October: “இளம் கலைஞர்களின் இதய ஓசை!” (The heartbeat of young artists!), S. Guru
1998	The Hindu, 11 September: “Questions on identity”, Lakshmi Venkatraman
2013	Tamil Murasu, November: Golden Point Award 2013
2014	Tabla!, 16 May: Bird Sanctum, Project LAVA

IMAGES, USE AND CONTACT

For editors

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Name. The artist's name is written baaskaraa, in lower case, also at the start of a sentence. In biographical text he is Baskar.

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baaskaraa

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b with me